My AI content engine's best draft refused to finish.

One article in. Five channel drafts out. Here is what five real test runs taught me about trusting AI with your name.

seo_blog_draft · run 4

GATE: FLAGGED

I do not have results to share yet, so `[CHECK: first-run timing, first-pass gate rate and edit rate, if you want to include real numbers]`.

One strong piece gets published once. Then it dies.



LinkedIn post	not written
X thread	not written
Newsletter section	not written
Short video script	not written
SEO article	not written

Each version is another rewrite for a different reader. So it never happens.

What I built in n8n

1 **Take one source**

Blog URL (Firecrawl), audio file (Whisper) or a pasted transcript. Under 150 words, it stops.

2 **Write a fact-only brief**

Claude Haiku 5.5. Facts copied word for word. Extract, do not invent.

3 **Draft each channel separately**

Claude Sonnet 5.5, one call per channel, each with its own format rules and my voice.

4 **Check every draft in plain code**

Length, format, hype words, and every number against the source.

5 **Queue for a human**

Every draft lands on an approval board as needs review. Nothing posts by itself.

The part I care about most is the boring part.

Before anyone reads a draft, a quality gate written in JavaScript checks it.

Right length for the channel?	`150–250 words, 280 chars`
Right format?	`hook, subject, H2s, CTA`
Any hype words?	`"revolutionize", "unlock"…`
Is every number in the source?	`"40% faster" → flagged`
Did the model leave a gap?	`[CHECK: …] → flagged`

What happened

Real test runs, 1 Nov 2026 · 4 full runs · 20 drafts

67–88s

from submit to five drafts on the board

15 / 20

drafts passed the gate on the first try

0

invented numbers across 20 drafts

$0.12

per run on a 900-word article, at API list prices

A 28-second audio clip came to 67 words. The guard stopped it before any AI call.

The prompt said under 270. The model wrote 281.

Then put it in the issue. Link the source, like Salesforce or Zendesk. Explain why they want it. Add context, like what they are building. Mention the PM.

Good example: a customer with more than 1000 users, sprint planning, current workaround. Bad example: a bare Salesforce link.

`x_thread · post 4` **281 / 280**

> `gate_notes: post 4 is 281 chars`

A prompt is a request. Code is a guarantee.

Real draft from a test run on a public GitLab Handbook page (CC BY-SA 4.0).

The best failure was a draft that asked for help.

I asked for an SEO article about the engine before I had results. It did not make any up.

`seo_blog_draft · "What to measure"`

That last one tells you the truth. If people rewrite most of a draft, the engine saved typing, not thinking. I do not have results to share yet, so `[CHECK: first-run timing, first-pass gate rate and edit rate, if you want to include real numbers]`.

A draft that says "I need a real number here" is worth more than one that sounds finished.

Testing found two bugs. Neither one crashed.

The brief ran out of room

Haiku spent 1,210 of its 2,000 output tokens on hidden reasoning, so the JSON brief was cut off. The SEO draft noticed the missing keyword and flagged it.

```
fix: budget 2,000 → 8,000, log reasoning tokens
```

My own gate was too strict

When I ran this write-up through the engine, all 5 drafts were flagged. They quoted the phrase "[CHECK] note". The gate could not tell a quote from a placeholder.

```
fix: match only "[CHECK:", add a unit test
```

Long sources cost 2.3× more. Not for the reason I expected.

899-word article **$0.12**



6,064-word page **$0.28**



Same page, source cached (estimate) **$0.16**



input visible output hidden reasoning

Each of the five draft calls re-sends the whole source: 92,000 input tokens. Caching it once is the next fix.

The PM lesson

Put the rules you cannot afford to break in code, not in the prompt.

Then design the failure state as carefully as the happy path.

Would you let AI post for you, or only draft?

Full case study, demo and the n8n workflow are in the comments.